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Abstract

Permanently snow-covered surfaces play a major role in amplifying climate variability due to their high albedo—their ability to reflect a large fraction of incoming solar radiation. In a rapidly warming climate, monitoring and understanding how surface processes influence snow radiative properties and their

spatiotemporal evolution is critical. This work focuses on the evolution of snow grain size in Antarctica, particularly in a megadunes field on the Eastern Antarctic Plateau, a remote and poorly understood region. We compare and exploit albedo measurements from both *in situ* automated albedometers and the Sentinel-3 Ocean and Land Color Instrument (OLCI). Albedo can be directly used to compute snow grain size via the asymptotic radiative transfer theory (Kokhanovsky & Zege, 2004). We obtained continuous, multi-year time series from five stations, enabling a deeper understanding of the impact of geophysical processes (precipitation, metamorphism, wind drift) on snow grain size, especially in the megadunes zone. We also compared *in situ* measurements with satellite-retrieved albedo at station locations to validate the latter for potential continent-wide, daily-scale monitoring of snow grain size. Results show moderate to good agreement at three stations (average $r = 0.66$, $p < 0.01$) but systematic differences at one megadunes station ($r = 0.39$, $p < 0.01$). Consequently, we developed a diagnostic pipeline for processing both *in situ* and satellite data, revealing likely instrumental drift in the albedometers and potential sub-optimal retrieval of snow grain size from satellite observations.

Resumé

Les surfaces recouvertes en permanence de neige jouent un rôle majeur dans l'amplification de la variabilité climatique grâce à leur albédo élevé, c'est-à-dire leur capacité à réfléchir une grande partie du rayonnement solaire incident. Dans un contexte de réchauffement climatique rapide, la surveillance et la compréhension de l'influence des processus de surface sur les propriétés radiatives de la neige et de leur évolution spatiotemporelle sont essentielles. Ce travail se concentre sur l'évolution de la taille des grains de neige en Antarctique, en particulier dans un champ de mégadunes sur le plateau antarctique oriental, une région reculée et mal comprise. Nous comparons et exploitons des mesures d'albédo provenant à la fois d'albédomètres automatisés *in situ* et de l'instrument satellite Sentinel-3 Ocean and Land Color Instrument (OLCI). L'albédo peut en effet être directement utilisé pour calculer la taille des grains de neige via la théorie asymptotique du transfert radiatif (Kokhanovsky & Zege, 2004). Nous avons obtenu des séries temporelles continues sur plusieurs années à partir de cinq stations, permettant une meilleure compréhension de l'impact des processus géophysiques (précipitations, métamorphisme, transport éolien) sur la taille des grains de neige, en particulier dans la zone des mégadunes. Nous avons également comparé les mesures *in situ* avec les albédos récupérés par satellite aux emplacements des stations afin de valider ces derniers pour un suivi potentiel à l'échelle continentale et quotidienne de la taille des grains de neige. Les résultats montrent un accord modéré à bon pour trois stations (corrélation moyenne $r = 0.66$, $p < 0.01$), mais des différences systématiques pour une station des mégadunes ($r = 0.39$, $p < 0.01$). Par conséquent, nous avons développé une chaîne de traitement diagnostique pour les données *in situ* et satellites, révélant une probable dérive instrumentale des albédomètres et un éventuel sous-optimisation de la récupération de la taille des grains de neige à partir des observations satellites.

I Introduction

Snow is one of the major component of the cryosphere. Its global distribution on both ocean and land areas strongly depends on seasonality, latitude, and elevation. It occurs in three forms, mainly: permanent snow on ice sheets and glaciers, snow on sea ice, and seasonal snow cover. The latter is estimated to account for 1.3% (summer) to 30.6% (winter) of the Northern Hemisphere land surface area (Vaughan et al., 2013), with the 1967–2026 mean snow cover extent (SCE hereafter) in winter being around $39.79 \times 10^6 \text{ km}^2$ (Robinson & Estilow, 2012). Sea ice is often covered by snow during the winter season; its peak extent occurs in March in the Northern Hemisphere ($15.03 \times 10^6 \text{ km}^2$) and in September in the Southern Hemisphere ($18.61 \times 10^6 \text{ km}^2$) (Fetterer et al., 2025; Warren et al., 1999). Finally, perennial snow mean extent over the 2000–2022 period is estimated at $16.47 \times 10^6 \text{ km}^2$ from NASA's Moderate Resolution Imaging Spectroradiometer (MODIS), including glaciers, ice caps, Greenland and Antarctica ice sheets (Johnston et al., 2024).

These several tens of millions of snow-covered squared kilometres play a major role in freshwater resources availability, ecosystems equilibrium and, particularly, climate variability amplification. In fact, snow represents one of the strongest reflective materials on Earth's surface. *Albedo* quantifies the fraction of incident solar radiation reflected by a surface. For fresh snow, broadband albedo (*i.e.*, integrated over the visible-to-infrared range) is close to 1, as its highest reflectivity occurs in the visible range, where solar radiation intensity peaks (Kokhanovsky & Zege, 2004). The radiative forcing of Northern Hemisphere land snow cover—its cooling effect on Earth's energy budget—averages approximately 2 W m^{-2} (1979–2008), peaking at 4.5 W m^{-2} in May (Flanner et al., 2011). Without this forcing, Earth's surface temperature would be approximately 0.54 K higher than the current planetary mean. This estimate assumes that Earth radiates as a blackbody with no feedback effects, making it a lower-bound estimate. In fact, real climate feedbacks (due to water vapour, lapse rate, clouds) amplify the true temperature response (Cronin & Dutta, 2023).

As the whole cryosphere in general, snow distribution on Earth is undergoing dramatic changes because of the current anthropogenic perturbation of the climate system and warming of the atmosphere. At the global scale, SCE is featuring a negative trend since the 1980s, with a statistically significant reduction in the mean area of 5% after 1988—compared to the 1967–1988 period and in the Northern Hemisphere only—and an earlier melt onset in the spring season (Dye, 2002; Robinson & Frei, 2000). Less snow cover in both space and time, driven by rising temperatures, reduces terrestrial albedo and increases the absorption of incoming solar radiation at the surface, which in turn amplifies warming (Cubasch et al., 2001; Holland & Bitz, 2003). This mechanism is known as the positive snow–albedo feedback: it is estimated to be responsible of a reduction in Northern Hemisphere land snow cover radiative cooling forcing of $\sim 0.22 \text{ W m}^{-2}$ from 1979 to 2007, which nearly equals the contribution of Arctic sea ice decline (Flanner et al., 2011). The magnitude of such feedback is further amplified when light-absorbing particles, such as

dust, black carbon and microbial growth, deposit on the surface of snowpack (Skiles et al., 2018).

It is clear, that developing a proper understanding of how snow interacts with solar radiation is crucial for a better understanding of the evolution of the climate system. Snow optical properties, particularly albedo, are directly related to grain type and size, and are strongly wavelength-dependent (Bohren & Barkstrom, 1974; Kokhanovsky & Zege, 2004). Quantifying these properties involves radiative transfer calculations extended to the uppermost part of the snowpack, which in most models is assumed to be composed of individual grains of a given size and shape. Many studies have adopted equivalent spheres, assuming they can properly represent any other shape at a given optical diameter (Bohren & Barkstrom, 1974; Warren et al., 1999). However, recent studies have demonstrated that this approach is unsatisfactory for accurately accounting for specific scattering and reflectance properties of the snowpack (Dumont et al., 2010; Kokhanovsky & Zege, 2004; Libois et al., 2014). For this reason, when addressing grain size, a more general, shape-independent quantity is preferable to the optical diameter: the *specific surface area* (SSA), defined as the total surface area of snow grains per unit mass—expressed in $\text{m}^2 \text{kg}^{-1}$ (International Union of Pure and Applied Chemistry (IUPAC), 2025). This quantity, used hereafter to address snow grain size, largely influences snow reflectance for wavelengths in the Near-Infrared (NIR) range, between 750 nm and 1400 nm particularly (Warren & Wiscombe, 1980). For example, a factor-6 decrease in SSA (e.g., from 60 to $10 \text{ m}^2 \text{kg}^{-1}$) can approximately reduce albedo by 15% at 1000 nm. In general, albedo decreases monotonically with SSA and can be modeled as an exponential function of $\text{SSA}^{-1/2}$ (Kokhanovsky & Zege, 2004).

Snow grain size dynamics are therefore a key indicator of how snowpack optical properties evolve over time and space, making their tracking essential. Changes in grain size are primarily driven by processes such as metamorphism, wind drift, and precipitation.

When transformations in size and shape occur below the melting point ($T = 0^\circ\text{C}$), the metamorphism is dry: the grain size grows at a rate defined by the respective increase in temperature and temperature gradient (Colbeck, 1982). Instead, wet metamorphism occurs if snow is at the melting point, the liquid water content directly driving the growth, which is significantly faster than in the dry case (Wakahama, 1968). Anyway, independently of the type of metamorphism, the change in size is positive and irreversible, exception made for few specific cases when the opposite occurs (melt-freeze crust turning into depth hoar, fragmentation of snow crystals by wind drift, and sieving of blowing snow by a snow layer, Domine et al., 2009).

Transport by the wind occurs when its velocity is able to break snow cohesion and lift grains. This is more likely for fresh-fallen snow than for old, metamorphosed snow (Lenaerts et al., 2017). This process, called wind drift, varies with wind speed: saltation occurs under weak winds, (from $4\text{--}6 \text{ m s}^{-1}$) with snow skipping a few centimeters above the surface, while stronger winds create snow plumes, lifting grains up to hundreds of meters—the so-called blowing snow (Adok, 1977; World Meteorological Organization, 2024). Wind drift has two opposing effects on grain size. Erosion of the snowpack's upper layers exposes older, coarser, and

less reflective layers (Lenaerts et al., 2017). Conversely, wind fractures grains through collisions, so newly formed deposits typically consist of finer grains (Domine et al., 2009).

Snow fall is generally responsible of depositing fresh and more fine-grained snow at surface, potentially covering already metamorphosed and coarser layers, thus increasing SSA and albedo (Domine et al., 2009).

This study is focused on the temporal evolution of snow and its albedo over the whole Antarctica, where all the processes of above act and interplay in a complex manner, over a wide range of climatic and geographical contexts. The Antarctic Ice Sheet (AIS), expanding for $14 \times 10^6 \text{ km}^2$ over 98% of the continent, is almost completely snow-covered year-round. As a polar region, it plays a massive role in positive climate feedbacks. At the same time, compared to the Arctic, Antarctica presents unique challenges for the exploration of surface radiative properties.

Being such a harsh and inaccessible place, it has allowed *in situ* investigations limited to regional scales and relatively short time coverage only. This has led the scientific community to rely on satellite data, which inherits higher uncertainties and reduced spatio-temporal resolution, from missions such as AVHRR, MODIS, and CLARA-A2.1-SAL (Calleja et al., 2019; Sun et al., 2023).

Moreover, many of the AIS surface processes are not yet properly understood, particularly toward the center of the ice sheet. One of these is the mechanism involved in the formation of snow megadunes. These are antidune-like sedimentary forms, whose fields cover a large fraction of the central part of the AIS ($500 \times 10^5 \text{ km}^2$) (Frezzotti et al., 2002). They have relatively small amplitudes (1–8 m), compared to their wavelength (2–4 km), and crest lengths of 10 to 100 km (Fahnestock et al., 2000)—these characteristics prevented their direct observation until the beginning of satellite exploration over the continent. Their formation are thought to result from a complex interplay between geomorphological and meteorological conditions that causes a cryosphere-atmosphere feedback mechanism: katabatic winds, blowing toward the outer boundaries of the AIS from the center, affect local topography by deposition-erosion processes [REF]. Topography, in turn, modifies the katabatic wind field; megadunes develop perpendicularly to the main direction of such winds (Traversa et al., 2023). Still, the way snow grain size evolves on these structures remains an unexplored topic.

With this work, we aim to improve the understanding of surface albedo evolution in Antarctica by combining *in situ* measurements with satellite observations in the megadune area. Using data from automated albedometers installed at several locations on the AIS, we aims to produce high accuracy quality-controlled time series of locally measured specific surface area (SSA) and assess them against satellite-retrieved grain size. Measurement stations were deployed in two primary locations: on the coast near the French station Dumont d'Urville, and in a megadune field in the Eastern Antarctic Plateau.

The overarching goals of this analysis are: (i) to validate a satellite product, ESA's Sentinel-3 Ocean and Land Color Instrument, enabling long-term and continent-wide studies of snow albedo at a relatively fine resolution ($\sim 300 \text{ m}$), compared to other missions (e.g., MODIS); (ii) to deepen the understanding of processes driving temporal albedo changes at the local scale, particularly on megadunes, using an

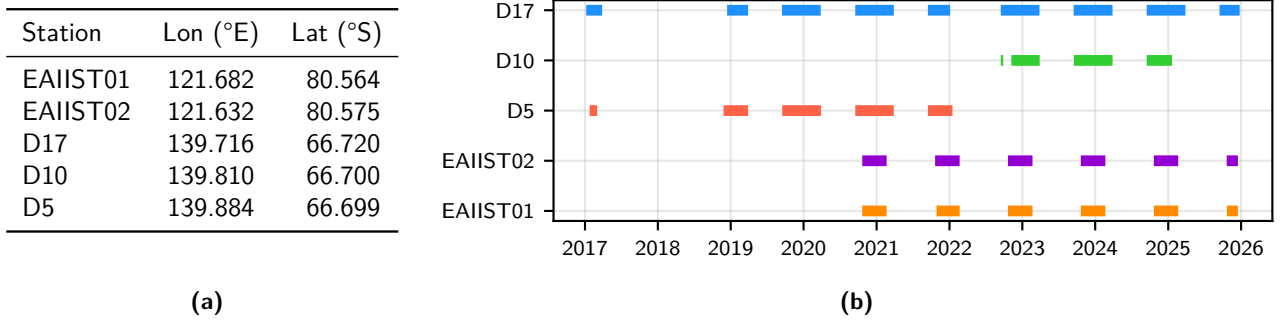


Figure 1: Stations overview | (a) Exact position of each measurement station in WGS 84 coordinates; (b) temporal data availability of each measurement station

unprecedented 6-year continuous *in situ* record of snow albedo.

The analysis is structured as follows:

1. **Processing of *in situ* data:** upgrading and optimizing the existing workflow developed by Arioli et al., 2023; this includes both processing data from the main instrument (Multiband and relative weather stations) and from Solalb, a second albedometer used as an external reference to assess the quality of Multiband and Sentinel-3 performances;
2. **Processing of Sentinel-3 data:** downloading the frames and applying the SICE 1.6 algorithm, as described by Kokhanovsky et al., 2019;
3. **Comparison of the time series:** performing corrections to address possible gaps between the two datasets and interpreting the retrieved albedo dynamics geophysically.

For this, I've adapted an existing algorithm to process in-situ measurements to the megadune site for the first time. This involved many changes and detailed verification of the signals. I've then selected, downloaded automatically (1Tb) processed OLCI satellite data using the existing algorithm SICE, and I've compared them to the in-situ data. The core of my work was data analysis of the in-situ data, in a context of complex instrumentation.

II Material and methods

1 Theoretical backgrounds

Snow can be considered an opaque medium from a radiative perspective, with nearly zero transmissivity. Its interaction with sunlight is thus limited to absorption or reflection, described by the bidirectional reflectance distribution function (BRDF) f_r for opaque bodies (Nicodemus, 1965) :

$$f_r(\theta_0, \theta', \phi_0, \phi', \lambda) = \frac{dL_r(\theta', \phi', \lambda)}{dE_i(\theta_0, \phi_0, \lambda)} \quad (\text{sr}^{-1}), \quad (1)$$

where (θ_0, ϕ_0) are the solar zenith (SZA) and azimuth (SAA) angles, (θ', ϕ') the reflected angles, and λ the wavelength. Here, L_r is the reflected spectral radiance ($\text{W m}^{-2} \text{sr}^{-1} \text{nm}^{-1}$), and $E_i = \mu_0 L_i d\theta_0 d\phi_0$ the incident spectral irradiance ($\text{W m}^{-2} \text{nm}^{-1}$), with $\mu_0 = \cos \theta_0$. For a satellite sensor, such as S-3/OLCI, the measured reflectance is given by the integral of f_r over its whole field of view (θ', ϕ') (Kokhanovsky et al., 2019).

For snow, Warren, 1982 defined the *direct albedo* α^{dir} as the spectral directional-hemispherical reflectance, characterizing snow reflectivity in clear-sky conditions (*i.e.*, with sunlight incident at a specific angle θ_0):

$$\alpha^{\text{dir}}(\theta_0, \lambda) = \int_0^1 \mu' d\mu' \int_0^{2\pi} f_r(\theta_0, \theta', \phi_0, \phi', \lambda) d\phi'. \quad (2)$$

Integrating α^{dir} over all incidence angles yields the *diffuse albedo* α^{dif} , a spectral bi-hemispherical reflectance, indeed expressing snow reflectance under diffuse light:

$$\alpha^{\text{dif}}(\lambda) = 2 \int_0^1 \mu_0 \alpha^{\text{dir}}(\mu_0, \lambda) d\mu_0. \quad (3)$$

Using Kokhanovsky et Zege, 2004's Asymptotic Radiative Transfer (ART) theory, snow grain size (SSA) can be retrieved from both α^{dir} and α^{dif} . Particularly, α^{dir} can be expressed in terms of α^{dif} by introducing the escape function, *i.e.*, the probability that a photon, after being repeatedly scattered within the snowpack, will escape the medium in a specific direction θ' (Sobolev, 1975) :

$$u(\mu') = \frac{3}{7}(1 + 2\mu') \quad (4)$$

Hence:

$$\alpha^{\text{dif}}(\lambda) = \exp \left(-4 \sqrt{\frac{2B\gamma(\lambda)}{3\rho_{\text{ice}}\text{SSA}(1-g)}} \right), \quad \alpha^{\text{dir}}(\lambda, \theta_0) = \alpha^{\text{dif}}(\lambda)^{u(\mu_0)} \quad (5)$$

where $\rho_{\text{ice}} = 917 \text{ kg m}^{-3}$ is the ice density at 0°C , $\gamma(\lambda)$ the ice absorption coefficient, and $B = 1.6$ and $g = 0.85$ are the absorption enhancement parameter and asymmetry factor, respectively (Libois et al., 2014). These expressions assume: (i) a homogeneous snowpack, (ii) a flat, horizontal surface with a horizontal albedometer sensor, (iii) constant g and B , together with SSA fully describing snow phase function and single-scattering albedo (iv) clean snow—realistic assumption for Antarctica, exception made for human-polluted sites (Casey et al., 2017). Finally, SSA is obtained by fitting the total albedo model $\alpha^{\text{mod}}(\lambda)$:

$$\alpha^{\text{mod}}(\lambda) = A \left[D^{\text{dif}}(\theta_0, \lambda) \alpha^{\text{dif}}(\lambda) + (1 - D^{\text{dif}}(\theta_0, \lambda)) \alpha^{\text{dir}}(\theta_0, \lambda) \right], \quad (6)$$

where $D^{\text{dif}}(\theta_0, \lambda)$ is the diffuse-to-total light partitioning (Picard et al., 2016), specific for the location and the observed meteorological conditions, and A is a scaling parameter accounting for wavelength-independent artifacts (*e.g.*, slope, varying illumination, or poor cross-calibration). SSA and A are retrieved by minimizing the squared differences between measured and modeled albedo spectra.

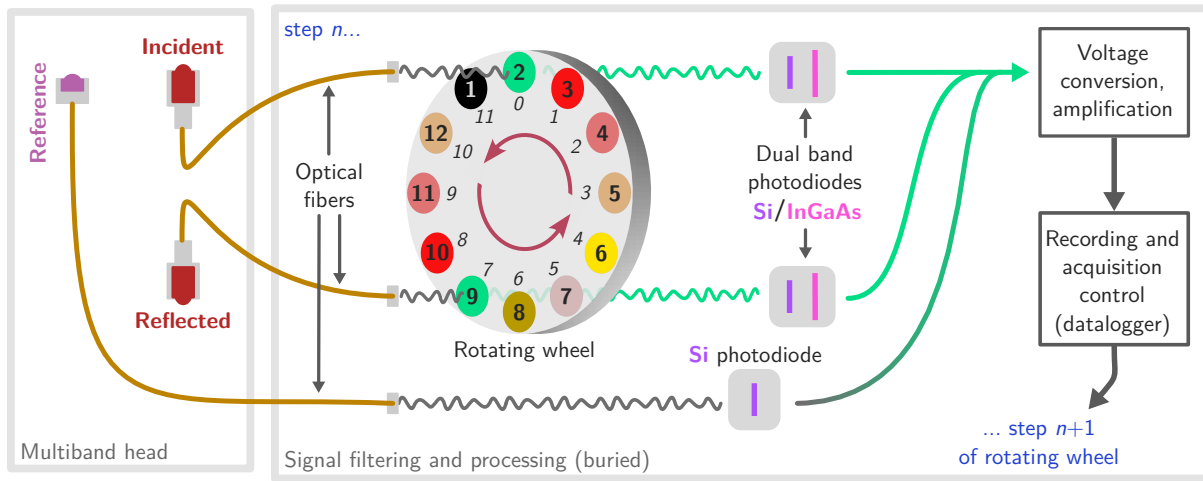


Figure 2: Structure of Multiband | On the head, custom cosine collectors (red) and the reference collector (purple). The signal is transmitted through slots 0 (incident channel) and 7 (reflected) of the wheel; at any step n , the wheel rotates of one slot counter-clockwise. Simultaneous acquisition on reflected and incident channels are possible at 500 (green), 800 (red), 1050 (pale red), and 1300 nm (light brown), thanks to duplicated filters (2-9, 3-10, 4-11 and 5-12 respectively). Dual photodiodes are composed of two stacked Si (purple) and InGaAs (pink) photodiodes. Modified after ARIOLI et al., 2023.

2 Study area: an overview of the stations

We employed data from five automated stations located across the Antarctic Ice Sheet. Their precise geolocalizations are shown in Figure ??, while the temporal availability of data for each station is presented in Figure 1b. Each station is equipped with an albedometer (described in Section 3.1) and an automated weather station (AWS).

Three stations are located on the coast, a few kilometers from the French station Dumont d'Urville at Cap Prud'homme. These stations were previously used in the study by Arioli et al., 2023. Data from these stations are recovered manually every year during the December–January field campaign by IGE operators. Hereafter, we refer to these as the ****coastal Cap Prud'homme stations****.

Two stations were installed in a megadune field near the South Pole in 2019 during the Franco-Italian **East Antarctic International Ice Sheet Traverse (EAIIST)**. This campaign enabled the exploration of a remote area of the East Antarctic Plateau for geophysical, chemical, and paleoclimatic research. The stations were deployed in the zones of maximum accumulation and maximum ablation of a dune, respectively, to investigate the processes of these snow sedimentary structures—one of the key objectives of this work. Due to the remoteness and inaccessibility of the location, data are automatically retrieved via satellite. Hereafter, we refer to these as the ****megadunes EAIIST stations****.

3 Material and instruments

3.1 *In situ*: the Multiband albedometer

The main instrument used in this study is the Multiband albedometer, developed at Grenoble's Institute for Geosciences of the Environment (IGE) and fully described in Arioli et al., 2023. It is a robust automated optical radiometer capable of acquiring solar radiation across a discrete set of wavelength bands, from the visible to the short-wave infrared, which are essential for retrieving snow surface albedo. Similar to previously developed albedometers (e.g., Autosolexs, Solalb; see Picard et al., 2016), the Multiband consists of a set of metal gantries. One perfectly leveled pole projects the instrument head horizontally at ~ 3 m from the installation point and at a height of ~ 2 m above the snow surface, typically oriented north- or southward to minimize shadowing from other components. The head features two custom cosine-shaped light collectors, one pointing upward and the other downward, to measure incident and reflected irradiance, respectively. These collectors, meticulously designed by Picard et al., 2016, incorporate a bumped Teflon surface to maximize performance at any solar zenith angle (SZA), including grazing angles, which are critical for accurate radiation measurements in polar regions.

The light is transmitted to the instrument's recording unit via two Ocean Optics QP800-VIS-NIR optical fibers, each 6 m long with a 800 μm core diameter. Unlike earlier albedometers, where optical fibers directly sent the signal to a spectrometer for high-resolution spectral recording, the Multiband employs a more energy-efficient approach. The broadband radiation transmitted by the fibers passes through a set of polarizing filters mounted on a ~ 20 cm wheel with 12 slots. These filters are Edmund Optics' TECHSPEC® hard-coated optical density (OD) 4.0, 25 nm bandpass filters, specific for wavelengths of 500, 600, 800, 925, 1050, 1300, and 1550 nm. During a full measurement cycle (lasting 30 s), the wheel rotates to acquire spectral measurements for each selected wavelength from both incident and reflected signals. These signals are transmitted to dual-band Silicon (Si) / Indium-Arsenide-Gallium (InGaAs) photodiodes, the latter sensible to signals at longer wavelengths. (DSD2, Thorlabs). Measurements on the two channels are simultaneous, and the wheel includes duplicate filters to ensure synchronous recordings at the most relevant wavelengths, as well as one capped slot to measure the dark current (*i.e.*, the background thermal noise). To ensure simultaneous acquisition of the most relevant wavelengths for albedo retrieval on both channels, four of the remaining free slots are filled with duplicate filters for 500, 800, 1050, and 1300 nm (Fig. 2). The signals registered by the dual photodiodes are amplified by a high-gain instrument amplifier. Finally, a Campbell Scientific CR1000x data logger records the signal in mV. Since the duration of a full measurement cycle is long enough for atmospheric conditions to potentially change, a measure of ambient light is also recorded at every step: a third upward-facing optical fiber transmits incoming radiation to a Si photodiode (FDS100, Thorlabs). This photodiode acquires a wideband measurement in the 350–1100 nm range, referred to as the reference, expressed in light counts. Its signal undergoes the same voltage amplification and recording steps as the spectral measurements; for a single cycle, 12 references are registered.

The entire system's electronics are powered by a solar panel. The Multiband has demonstrated its

durability by acquiring continuous measurements without interruption at each of the stations where it was installed over 7 years.

3.2 *In situ*: the Solalb albedometer

Solalb is a portable albedometer. Its functioning is different from Multiband. Its head consists of a single light collector that is manually flipped upward and downward during the measurement to acquire incident and reflected radiation respectively. The signal is transmitted to a 350–1100 nm spectrometer with a 3 nm sensibility. For every measurement, ten upward and ten downward spectra at 3 nm resolution are acquired, their average is finally taken and their standard deviation is used to exclude measurements performed under unstable light conditions. We use one-time Solalb measurements taken at a few locations here to complement the timeseries from Multiband. These measurements were acquired during 2019 EAIIST campaign, at different locations in the Eastern AIS, and during 2022 ICORDA campaign, in the same fixed location over 20 days.

3.3 *In situ*: automatic weather stations (AWS)

Each AWS is equipped with (i) sensors for temperature, wind speed and relative humidity at 2 and 4 m height; (ii) a CNR4 four-flux radiometer (Campbell Scientific) measuring shortwave (300–2800 nm) and long wave (5000–50 000 nm) radiation in four components (upward/downward shortwave and longwave); (iii) SR50 Ultrasonic Snow Depth Sensor, providing snow height measurements with a resolution of 1 mm and an accuracy of ± 1 cm (Campbell Scientific). All AWS data are synchronized with the Multiband albedometer at the same time step, ensuring temporal consistency across instruments.

3.4 Satellite imagery: Sentinel-3 Ocean Land and Colour Instrument

Ocean and Land Colour Instrument (OLCI) is installed on ESA's Sentinel-3, which operates in a sun-synchronous polar orbit, at an altitude of 814.5 km, providing global coverage. It acquires data across 21 spectral bands, ranging from the Visible to the Near infrared (400–1020 nm) with a spatial resolution of ~ 300 m at nadir and a swath width of 1270 km, enabling sub-daily revisits at high latitudes. OLCI's design is primarily oriented towards ocean color monitoring but is also highly effective for terrestrial applications, including snow and ice albedo retrieval. OLCI Level-1B and Level-2 products are freely accessible via the Copernicus Open Access Hub. For this study, we used Level-2 surface reflectance products.

4 Methods

4.1 Processing of Multiband data

4.1.a Overview of the existing algorithm

The pipeline for processing Multiband data is summarized in Figure 3 and builds on the work of Arioli et al., 2023. It executes functions from a custom Python library specifically developed for this purpose

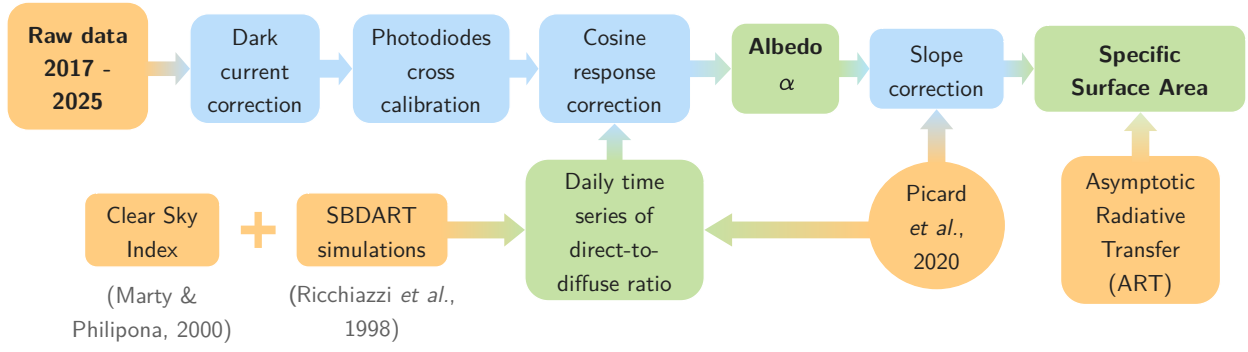


Figure 3: Workflow of Multiband processing | Modified after ARIOLI et al., 2023

(the `generic_algorithm`), along with utilities from the open-source module `snowoptics` (GitHub), a library for retrieving snow optical properties based on the Asymptotic Radiative Transfer theory (ART, Kokhanovsky et Zege, 2004). This processing had already been applied to measurements acquired by all three Cap Prud'Homme stations (D5, D10, D17) until 2022 in Arioli et al., 2023's work.

1. Raw data filtering | A preprocessing step excludes low-quality data, including: (i) measurements acquired at $\text{SZA} > 70^\circ$ due to the limited performance of cosine collectors at low solar angles (Picard et al., 2016); (ii) measurements acquired under varying or low ambient light conditions, if the standard deviation of the 12 references recorded during a cycle exceeds 1% of their mean radiance; and (iii) all records at 1550 nm due to the poor signal-to-noise ratio. A first set of spectral reflected and incident measurements is now exploitable; we refer to this raw voltage records as $i_{\text{raw}}^{\text{ref}}(\lambda, t)$ and $i_{\text{raw}}^{\text{inc}}(\lambda, t)$, with t the date and time of the measurement.

2. Dark current | The measurements are corrected for the background thermal noise of the photodiodes. Four dark currents are registered at every cycle (Si and InGaAs, for both the incident and reflected channels) and subsequently subtracted from the respective channel's spectral irradiance. For the reflected channel (and analogously for the incident), the dark corrected spectral signal $i^{\text{ref}}(\lambda, t)$ results from:

$$i^{\text{ref}}(\lambda, t) = i_{\text{raw}}^{\text{ref}}(\lambda, t) - i_{\text{dark}}^{\text{ref}}(\lambda, t) \quad (7)$$

3. Cross-calibration | The incident and reflected signals passing through the cosine collectors and the optical fibers naturally differ due to varying transmissivity and sensitivity of the components in the two channels. To account for this, a parallel cross-calibration (CC) is performed during the installation of the albedometers. At installation time, this involved orienting both light collectors upward and side-by-side to record the same irradiance over two days at an hourly resolution (every 10 minutes at solar noon). The two signals are then corrected following steps 1 and 2 of the current processing chain, averaged, and their ratio is multiplied by every incident spectrum measured during the operational stage of the albedometer to compensate for differences in the electronic response of the two channels. Formally, given the reflected and incident spectral signals averaged from the whole calibration experiment $i_{\text{cal}}^{\text{ref}}(\lambda)$ and $i_{\text{cal}}^{\text{inc}}(\lambda)$, their ratio

$R_{CC}(\lambda)$ is used to scale the incident spectral signal: :

$$i^{inc}(\lambda, t) \leftarrow i^{inc}(\lambda, t) R_{CC}(\lambda), \quad R_{CC}(\lambda) = \frac{i_{cal}^{ref}(\lambda)}{i_{cal}^{inc}(\lambda)} \quad (8)$$

4. Cosine response correction | Each light collector behaves uniquely at different solar angles under perfectly direct light conditions, with its response always diverging by a given amount ($\sim 1\text{--}6\%$) from an ideal cosine curve. For this reason, before deployment in the field, every collector's response was calibrated in the lab by illuminating it with a direct light beam at different angles. This experimental response is used by the algorithm to normalize every measurement. Since this correction step only involves the direct component of the incident radiation—not its diffuse part or the fully diffused reflected light—the direct-to-diffuse light ratio must be quantified for every measurement. This ratio depends on: (i) atmospheric characteristics at the specific geographical location (longitude, latitude, altitude); (ii) solar elevation, *i.e.*, the SZA; and (iii) meteorology at the time of the measurement, particularly cloud cover. To account for the first two factors, a time-independent, direct-to-diffuse partitioning is simulated using the Santa Barbara DISORT Atmospheric Radiative Transfer (SBDART) model (Ricchiazzi et al., 1998). Cloud cover is quantified using the 30-minute resolution recordings of the AWS located near the albedometers, with the methodology proposed by Marty et Philipona, 2000. These two steps will be detailed later.

5. Albedo calculation | The ratio between the dark- and cosine-corrected incident and reflected records yields a first estimation of spectral albedo at time t , $\alpha(\lambda, t)$:

$$\alpha(\lambda, t) = \frac{i^{ref}(\lambda, t)}{i^{inc}(\lambda, t)} \quad (9)$$

with $i^{inc}(\lambda, t)$ resulting from cross calibration of Equation (8). At this stage, no hypotheses are made about the geometry of snow surface. Moreover, values of $\alpha < 0$ and $\alpha > 1.5$ are discarded.

6. Slope correction | Albedo is then corrected for potential slope and surface irregularities (*e.g.*, sastrugi) characterizing the snow surface on the day of the measurement, following Picard et al., 2020. The custom function `generic_algorithm.albedo_timeseries_correction()` is used to iteratively compute the unknown slope parameters that best fit the within-day evolution of the previously retrieved albedo spectra. At the end of this step, a daily averaged, slope-corrected albedo spectrum is produced.

7. SSA estimate | Kokhanovsky et Zege, 2004's ART theory is finally used to compute the snow grain size (SSA) from the daily albedo, as previously described in the theoretical background section.

4.1.b New implementations

In the present work, we extend the pipeline to the latest 2026 records and adapt it to the two stations installed on a megadune during the 2019 EAIIST campaign, which had never been processed yet. Additionally, we focus on characterizing the atmosphere at the two main locations and perform several diagnostics to investigate potential instrumental issues.

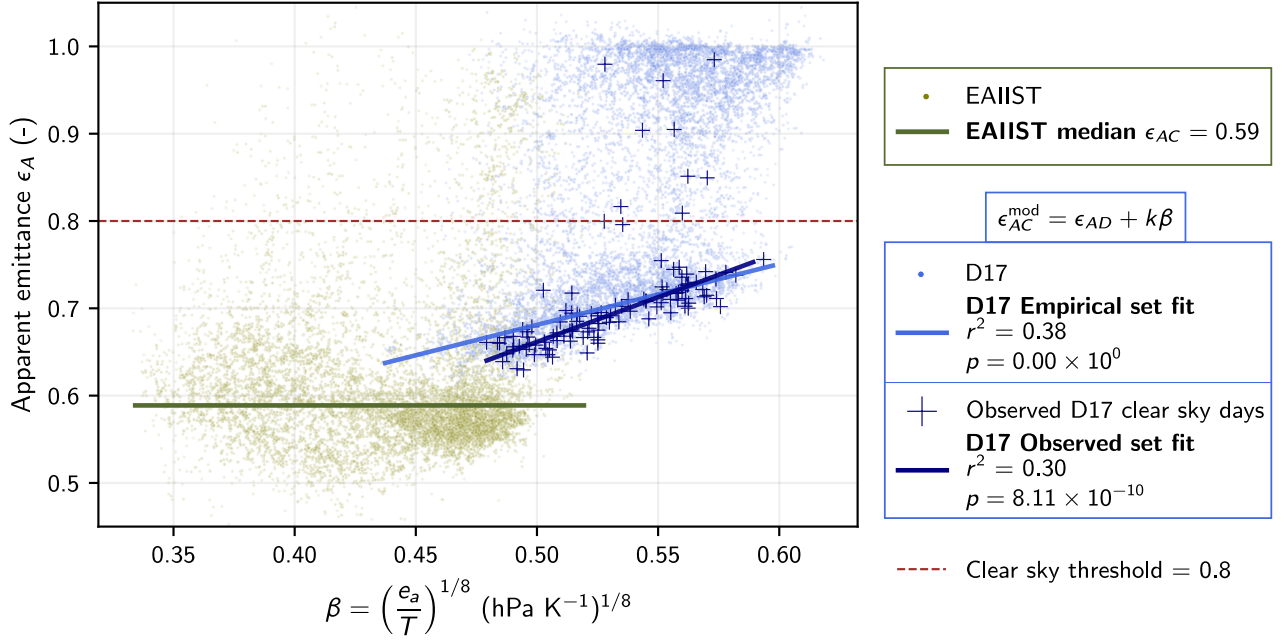


Figure 4: Apparent clear sky emissivity model | Summer days emissivities from 2014 to 2025 at D17, from CNR4 records (right-most dots scatterplot, blue); the model is fitted to points satisfying $\epsilon_A \leq 0.8$ (lower subset, *i.e.*, the Empirical clear sky set); emissivities from days identified as clear sky using D17’s camera (*i.e.*, the Observed clear sky set, crosses scatterplot, dark blue); emissivities derived from ERA5 records in the megadunes field at EAIIST stations (left-most dot scatter, green).

Direct-to-diffuse light ratio

Simulations of direct/diffuse partitioning with SBDART consist of computing SZA-specific spectral irradiance curves, both of global and diffuse fraction, and taking their ratio. We performed these calculations for the megadunes area using the following model parameters: **pristine** atmosphere (likely no pollution in the centre of the AIS), **sub-arctic winter** atmosphere type (the closest option available), 3000 m a.s.l. elevation, temperature $T = -35.8^\circ\text{C}$, relative humidity $\text{RH} = 0.70$, with the last two parameters being the daily average in the megadunes area over the 2019–2026 summers, retrieved from the CNR4 records. SBDART simulations return total and direct ($I_{\text{tot}}(\lambda)$ and $I_{\text{dir}}(\lambda)$) irradiance spectra for wavelengths between $0.3\ \mu\text{m}$ and $4\ \mu\text{m}$ at a $0.2\ \mu\text{m}$ resolution. From this, a diffuse-to-total ratio can be easily retrieved; the direct-to-diffuse is then calculated as follows:

$$\frac{I_{\text{dir}}(\lambda)}{I_{\text{dif}}(\lambda)} = \left(\frac{I_{\text{dif}}(\lambda)}{I_{\text{tot}}(\lambda)} \right)^{-1} - 1 \quad (10)$$

These ratios are also used in the processing chain during slope correction and SSA estimation, where either the direct-to-diffuse or the diffuse-to-total ratio can be provided as inputs, depending on the specific function.

Clear Sky Index (CSI) for cloud masking

We employed Marty et Philipona, 2000's technique to discriminate between overcast and clear-sky conditions using the *Clear Sky Index* (CSI), which involves comparing the emissivity of the observed atmosphere with that of an ideal cloud-free atmosphere with the same properties. Clouds generally increase the emittance of the atmosphere, as they act as near-blackbodies in the thermal infrared. The emissivity of the atmosphere can be directly derived from air temperature T_A and the incoming long-wave radiation $LW^\downarrow$ using the Stefan-Boltzmann law:

$$\epsilon_A = \frac{LW^\downarrow}{\sigma T_A^4} \quad (-) \quad (11)$$

with $\sigma \approx 5.67 \times 10^{-8} \text{ Wm}^{-2}\text{K}^{-4}$ being the Stefan-Boltzmann constant. To determine the apparent emissivity of a clear sky atmosphere ϵ_{AC} , vertical temperature and water vapour profiles can be used, but these were not available for our Antarctic sites. Instead, the formula presented by Brutsaert, 1975 allows the calculation of cloud-free emittance by fitting a model over observed clear-sky cases, each with known air temperature and dew point temperature T_d :

$$\epsilon_{AC} = k\beta, \quad \beta = \left(\frac{e_a}{T_A} \right)^{1/8} \quad (12)$$

with k a location-dependent coefficient, and e_a the water vapour pressure (hPa). The latter can be obtained by multiplying the saturation water vapour pressure e_s by the relative humidity $RH = \frac{e_a(T_A)}{e_s(T_d)}$, with e_s given by Clausius-Clapeyron relation via Tetens formula:

$$e_s = 6.11 \times \frac{10^{(7.5T_A)}}{T_A + 273.3} \quad (T_A \text{ in } ^\circ\text{C}) \quad (13)$$

One issue with this formulation is that it does not account for the effect of greenhouse gases other than water vapour, especially relevant in the dry Antarctic conditions. For this reason, an additional parameter ϵ_{AD} can be added to Equation (12), representing the altitude-dependent emittance of a perfectly dry atmosphere:

$$\epsilon_{AC}^{\text{mod}} = \epsilon_{AD} + k\beta \quad (14)$$

Station/set	$\epsilon_{AC}^{\text{mod}}$	$\sigma_{\epsilon_{AD}}$	k	σ_k
D17 Observed clear sky set fit	0.15	9.51×10^{-3}	1.03	1.79×10^{-2}
D17 Empirical clear sky set fit	0.30	6.58×10^{-4}	0.70	1.27×10^{-3}
EAIIST full summer set fit	0.59	6.23×10^{-2}	0	-

Table 1: Coefficients for clear sky emittance model ϵ_{AC} | For D17, the standard deviations of the two modelled coefficients are also reported. For EAIIST, the model is constant—the given standard deviation on the intercept is computed from all the points $\epsilon_A \leq 0.8$.

The only required inputs are records of air temperature, incoming long-wave radiation, and relative

humidity (or dew point temperature). The model is fitted to obtain the two unknowns (ϵ_{AD} , k) and derive a reliable expression for ϵ_{AC} as a function of the location's geography and prevailing meteorological conditions. This is achieved through an iteratively reweighted least squares regression over five iterations: at each step, the model is fitted on the current cluster, residuals are computed, and the 25% of points with the largest residuals are discarded—outliers are thus progressively eliminated, and each subsequent iteration operates on a cleaner subset. This derivation was first carried out for Cap Prud'homme using data from the CNR4 installed at D17, which is also equipped with a camera framing the surrounding environment, allowing a reliable visual identification of clear-sky days. In Figure 4, the apparent emittance of these observed cloud-free days is plotted as function of the water vapour pressure-to-temperature ratio; fitting Equation (14) to these data yields the coefficients summarised in Table 1. Plotting additionally the apparent emittance of all days from the summers 2014–2025 at D17 reveals a bi-modal distribution: the uppermost concentrated branch represents overcast days, with measured emittances approaching 1, while the lower branch is largely composed of clear-sky days, characterised by lower emittances at slightly drier conditions (*i.e.*, lower β). Separating the two clusters with a hard threshold set at $\epsilon_A = 0.8$, yields a second, more empirical set of clear-sky cases; fitting the same model to this subset returns coefficients comparable to those obtained from the manually identified clear-sky days. This second parameter set was ultimately selected for the ϵ_{AC} model at Cap Prud'homme, because of its smaller uncertainties. The statistics for these models reveal that the variability in ϵ_A is moderately dependent on β , with a high significance level.

For the EAIIST stations, CNR4 data were unavailable; the expression for the clear-sky apparent emittance was therefore derived from ERA5 reanalysis single-level fields, using $LW^\downarrow$, 2 m air temperature, and dew point temperature at hourly resolution. First, ERA5 performance was assessed against the D17 CNR4 record (Fig. 5) to validate the approach. Applying the same analysis as for Cap Prud'homme to the summers of 2019–2026 yields a distribution of daily emittances concentrated in much lower ranges (around 0.6) and at considerably drier conditions—much weaker water vapour pressure—reflecting the extreme aridity of the megadunes region. In this case, however, the model fails to reproduce the variability of apparent emittance, yielding $r^2 < 0.1$ (statistically highly significant, $p < 0.001$), and is therefore not applicable as is. Hence, For the EAIIST sites, we decided to treat the clear-sky emittance as a constant, taken as the median of all observed values satisfying $\epsilon_A \leq 0.8$, with no dependence on the water vapour pressure-to-temperature ratio.

Once established an expression for ϵ_{AC} , the CSI can be computed from the meteorological variables measured at any time t :

$$CSI(t) = \frac{\epsilon_A(t)}{\epsilon_{AC}(t)} \quad (-). \quad (15)$$

When the CSI exceeds 1, the sky is likely overcast, as the observed emittance exceeds the clear-sky reference; values below 1 correspond to cloud-free skies. A boolean cloud mask is defined accordingly, with 1 denoting overcast ($CSI \geq 1$) and 0 denoting clear-sky conditions ($CSI < 1$). For Antarctica, due to the frequent

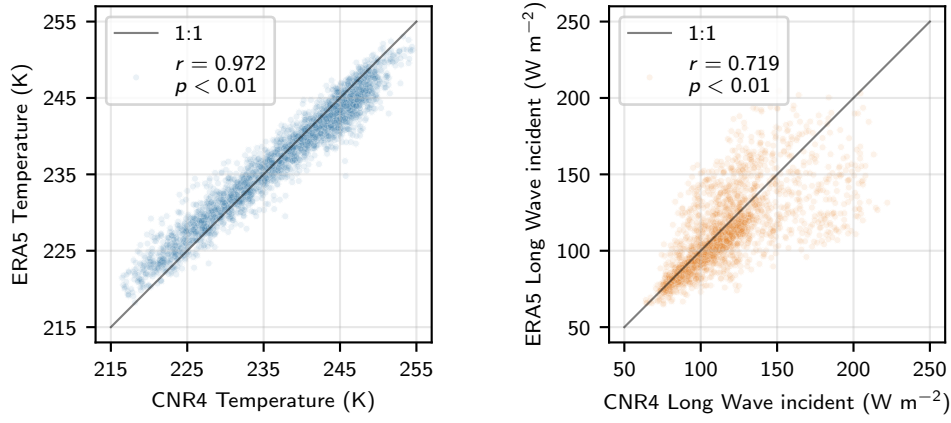


Figure 5: ERA5 and CNR4 measurements at D17 | ERA5 temperatures (left) and long wave incident irradiances (right) plotted against CNR4 respective records.

presence of thin cloud layers (e.g., cirrus, haze) that exhibit clear-sky-like behaviour, the threshold is set to 1.25 rather than 1 (Arioli et al., 2023).

A day is ultimately classified as clear sky if the mean of its cloud mask values is below 0.25, *i.e.*, at least 75% of sub-daily measurements are cloud-free, and as overcast otherwise. Clear-sky days are assigned the direct-to-diffuse irradiance partition modelled with SBDART, while overcast days are treated as fully diffuse across all wavelengths.

Diagnostic procedures

- **Calibration curves** | Cross calibration is the first step of the processing that must be analysed when instrumental issues arise. The related files allow a precise examination of the signal recorded by the two cosine collectors in the same upward position, and of their ratio at different wavelengths R_{CC} . Particularly, we expect this ratio to be fairly close to 1, meaning that the instrumental differences between the two channels are minimal. Values exceeding 1 of more than $\pm 20\%$ must arouse suspicion, as they could affect first albedo estimations by non-negligible amounts, following Equations (8) and (9).

- **Inclinometer time series** | Further issues can come from pronounced tilting of the albedometer (e.g., under strong winds), that can negatively impact the albedo retrieval by complicating slope correction. Every Multiband is equipped with an inclinometer recording the bidirectional tilting of the albedometer's head (θ_1, θ_2) at the same temporal resolution of the light collectors. From this, time series of both angles can be traced to investigate whether the head is leaning or not. This analysis is particularly useful for the two EAIIST stations, that cannot be re-adjusted for logistical reasons, and can help identify if it is necessary to apply an *a posteriori* correction factor.

- **Sub-daily variability in the signal** | Further insights can be gained by analyzing the temporal evolution of the signal at each wavelength and correction step. If the albedometer is functioning correctly, the signal after dark subtraction should exhibit a wavelength- and time-independent offset, particularly with respect to the SZA. Additionally, under near-perfect direct light conditions, the cross-calibrated and cosine-corrected

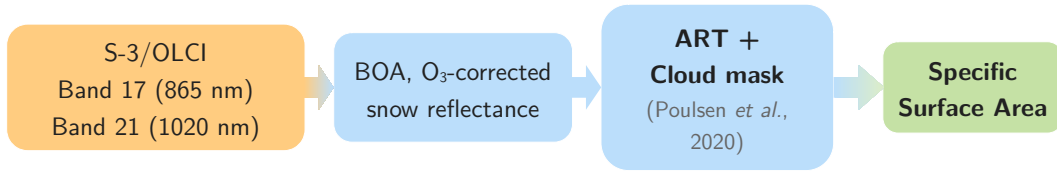


Figure 6: SICE 1.6 processing chain

signal should be symmetric about solar noon if the light collector is perfectly leveled. Finally, the daily variability of albedo spectra can be examined because calibration issues can lead to a non-convergence to ≈ 1.0 (0.98 exactly) in the visible range as expected. To ensure the inspected signals were acquired under optimal solar angles, only mid-summer days were selected (December 10 to January 20). Moreover, we targeted constant diffuse light conditions to minimize slope effects (Picard et al., 2020)—we selected overcast days with average CSI ≥ 0.97 and standard deviation below 0.1, along with a daily relative deviation in the reference photodiode below 0.01.

4.2 Processing of Solalb data

Solalb records are processed analogously to Multiband ones except cross calibration, as there is only one light collector on the head. Each experiment reports a quality tag (A+, A, B, C) set by the operator in the field indicating the consistency of spectra throughout the experiment, e.g. depending on the variability of light conditions. Only A and A+ records are selected, with less than 10% internal variability between the ten upward and downward measurements. The direct-to-diffuse ratio is measured directly with the instrument. This consists of first measuring the total incoming radiation with the upward-oriented collector; then, a small metal shield is positioned in front of the collector to remove the direct component of radiation and record the diffuse fraction only. The two signals—total and diffuse—are saved on the incident and reflected channels, respectively. This experiment is usually carried out once a day, and the direct-to-diffuse ratio can be obtained from Equation (10). For a single day, several Solalb experiments can be executed—either on a transect of a few tens of meters or in the same position. The daily SSA is retrieved from the average of each experiment.

4.3 SICE 1.6 processing chain

The retrieval of snow properties from OLCI data was fully implemented by Kokhanovsky et al., 2019 in the "Pre-Operational Sentinel-3 Snow and Ice Product" (SICE) algorithm; we adopted for our analysis version 1.6. A translation and optimisation from the former Fortran code to Python was also carried out by Baptiste Vandecrux and Ghislain Picard—we employed modules `sice_io` and `sice_lib`, the first for downloading the data, the second to process them.

The synthetic functioning is shown in Figure 6. The whole processing, in our specific case, has been run under the hypothesis of clean snow: no pollution is being accounted for our five sites at Cap Prud'homme and in the megadunes field, coherently with the choice of a pristine atmosphere for SBDART simulations.

The pipeline of SICE processing from raw OLCI data to SSA maps can be summarized as follows:

1. **Bands selection** | OLCI bands 17 ($\lambda_1 = 865 \text{ nm}$) and 21 ($\lambda_2 = 1020 \text{ nm}$) are first selected. The choice of this pair of bands is designed to minimize and maximize the albedo's sensitivity to grain size, while also avoiding the influence of impurities and Chappuis band absorption.

2. **Reflectance and filtering of pixels unsuitable for retrieval** | Top of atmosphere reflectances (R_{TOA}) for both bands are directly available after a first preprocessing selection step, that discards low values of reflectance $R_{\text{TOA}} < 0.1$ and high SZAs ($\text{SZA} > 75^\circ$).

3. **Definition of viewing geometry** | The function `sice_lib.view_geometry()` takes as inputs the filtered OLCI scene and outputs the angles necessary for the retrieval, particularly the satellite's Viewing Azimuthal Angle (VAA), cosines and sines of SZA and VZA (Viewing Zenithal Angle). It also computes the escape function for both SZA and VZA directions.

4. **Atmospheric correction** | TOA reflectances are corrected for ozone absorption and for the observed aerosol optical thickness. Both the corrections depend on the previously defined viewing/relative angles and elevation. This step outputs a bottom of atmosphere reflectance R_{BOA} , R here-hence.

5. **Retrieval of snow SSA** | This is the main processing step executed via the `sice_lib.snow_properties()` function and it is based on one of most relevant results of the ART theory: snow reflectance in the visible and NIR is function of spectral bulk ice absorption coefficient $a(\lambda)$ (mol m^{-1}), the reflectance of a non-absorbing snow R_0 and the absorption length l_{abs} (m) only:

$$R(\lambda) = R_0 \exp\left(-f \sqrt{a(\lambda) l_{\text{abs}}}\right) \quad (16)$$

R_0 and l can be computed from measurements at the two selected wavelengths λ_1, λ_2 :

$$R_0 = R_1^\epsilon R_2^{(1-\epsilon)}, \quad \epsilon = \left(1 - \sqrt{\frac{a_1}{a_2}}\right)^{-1} \simeq 1.5496 \quad (17)$$

and

$$l_{\text{abs}} = \frac{1}{a_2 f^2} \ln\left(\frac{R_1}{R_2}\right), \quad f = \frac{u(\text{SZA})u(\text{VZA})}{R_0} \quad (18)$$

with f being the angular function (Kokhanovsky & Zege, 2004). From absorption length expressed in mm, the effective optical diameter can be easily retrieved, and at its turn SSA can finally be estimated:

$$d = \frac{l_{\text{abs}}}{9.2 \times 16/9}, \quad \text{SSA} = \frac{6}{d \rho_{\text{ice}}} \quad (19)$$

From $R(\lambda)$, more properties are also computed (plane spectral albedo, broadband albedo) but they are not used in this work.

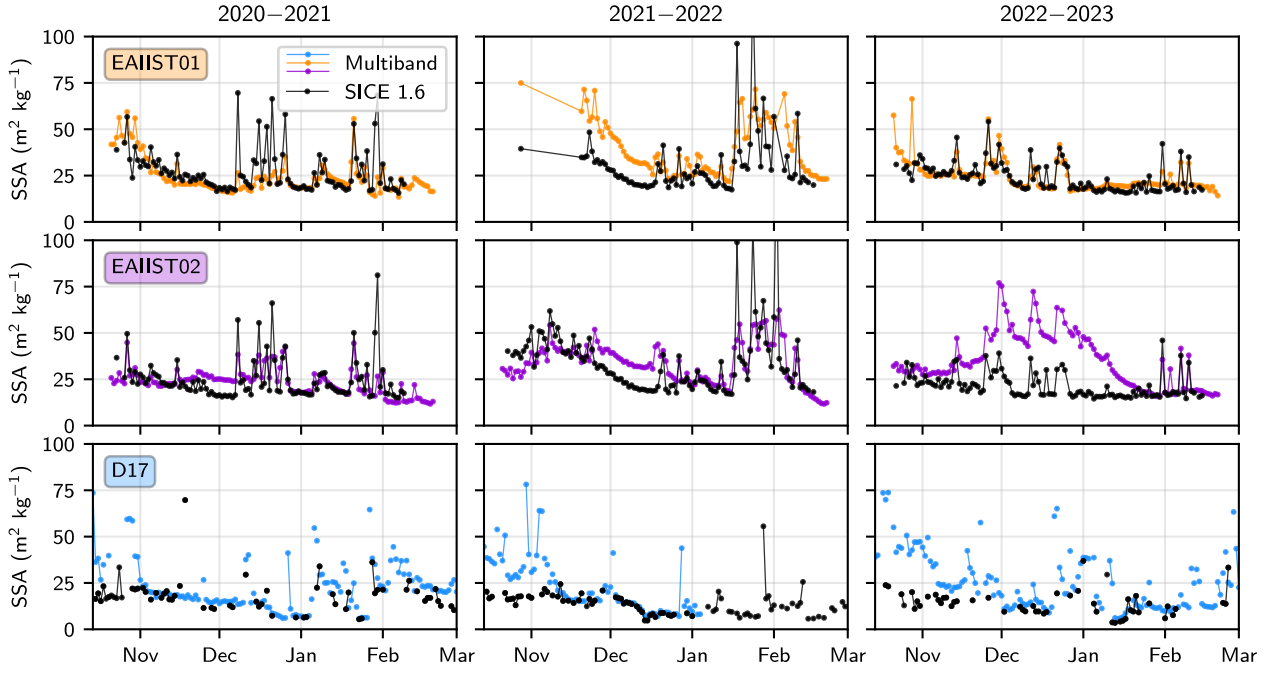


Figure 7: SSA time series from Multiband and SICE 1.6 | SSA estimated from Multiband (colors) and from SICE 1.6 (black) at EAIIST01 (orange), EAIIST02 (purple) in the megadunes and at D17 near Cap Prud’Homme (blue) for selected austral summers (other years in Appendix).

4.3.a Diagnostic techniques

The main potential issue with SICE 1.6-retrieved SSAs is the artificial dependence of the estimated SSA on solar angles during a day, induced by an uncertainty in the escape function (Equations (4) and (18)). Since we do not expect grain size to vary significantly during the day—unless due to precipitation or metamorphism—any observed changes in SSA are likely SZA-induced artifacts and must be investigated.

To address this, we performed different processing tests. The first, serving as the reference (REF), leaves the algorithm unchanged. The second (and further ones) introduce a flattening term to the escape function in `sice_lib.view_geometry(r)`:

$$u(\mu) \leftarrow u(\mu)(1 - r) + r \quad (20)$$

where r was initially tested at 0.3 and progressively increased to 0.4 in subsequent simulations. By adding this factor, we artificially reduce the dependence of SSA estimates on solar angles, allowing us to evaluate the effectiveness of the algorithm.

III Results

5 Time series from Multiband and SICE 1.6

Time series of snow SSA were successfully obtained for all five stations from both Multiband records and SICE 1.6 results. A representative summer for both locations is shown in Figure 7 and all years are

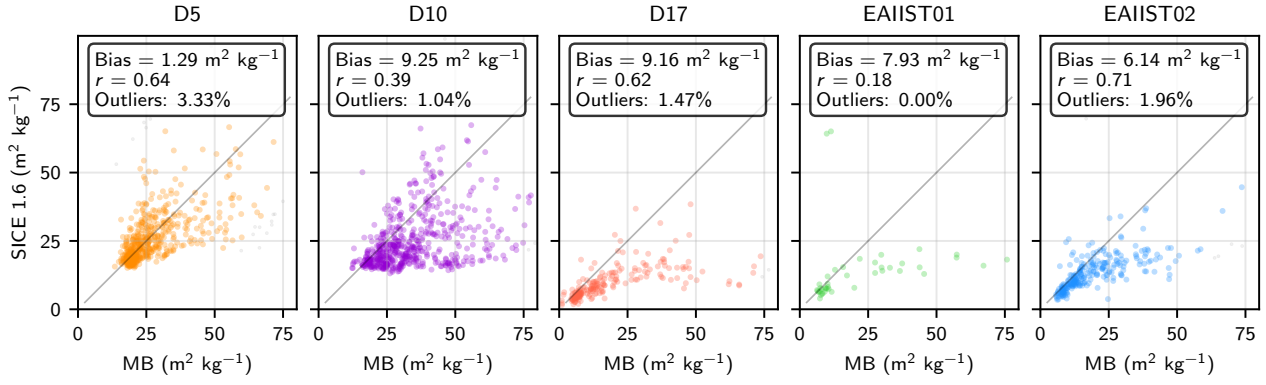


Figure 8: Correlation between Multiband and SICE 1.6 | SICE 1.6's SSAs plotted as function of Multiband SSAs for the two megadunes stations and the three Cap Prud'Homme stations, for all the available Multiband data. All statistics are computed exclusively on non-outliers and are significant at $p < 0.01$.

reported in Appendix ???. The comparison between Multiband and SICE 1.6 for all years is shown for each station in Figure 8. Points are respectively colored and gray depending whether they are under or exceeding three times the bias between the two methods—in the second case, they are defined as outliers.

In the megadunes, Multiband-measured SSA time series have been uninterrupted since 2019. SSA values are generally higher than $20 \text{ m}^2 \text{kg}^{-1}$, with a median of $25.6 \text{ m}^2 \text{kg}^{-1}$, reflecting the absence of wet metamorphism. The signals from the two stations typically diverge in mid-summer:

- At EAIIST01, the SSA signal stabilizes from late November around $20 \text{ m}^2 \text{kg}^{-1}$, with a December–January median of $21.44 \text{ m}^2 \text{kg}^{-1}$; this pattern repeats consistently every year.
- At EAIIST02, two distinct dynamics are observed. In the first case (summers of 2020, 2021, and 2024), SSA co-evolves with the erosion area, maintaining higher values (median over the three years: $25.19 \text{ m}^2 \text{kg}^{-1}$). In the second case (summers of 2022, 2023, and 2025), SSA rapidly increases in November, fluctuates around much higher values in December (median of the three years: $51.35 \text{ m}^2 \text{kg}^{-1}$), then decreases in January, tapering to values similar to those of EAIIST01 by February.

The SICE 1.6 time series for the megadunes show very few interruptions. For this region, SICE 1.6's missing values represent only 11.97% and 12.24% of Multiband data for EAIIST01 and EAIIST02, respectively. At EAIIST01 (erosion side of the dune), the difference between Multiband and satellite SSAs is much lower than at the coastal stations. However, despite a moderate linear correlation ($r = 0.64$), Multiband systematically registers higher SSAs during the 2021–2022 season, with a gap $10.00 \text{ m}^2 \text{kg}^{-1}$ from SICE 1.6 results—for all the other years the offset is below $2 \text{ m}^2 \text{kg}^{-1}$. This discrepancy has more interannual variability at EAIIST02 (accumulation side of the dune, Fig. 8), where the correlation between both datasets is therefore poorer ($r = 0.39$). In particular, SICE 1.6 at EAIIST02 yields SSAs much closer to those of the erosion area, *i.e.*, remaining constant around $20 \text{ m}^2 \text{kg}^{-1}$ throughout the summer. To understand and address these differences, we proceed with the diagnostics described in the Methods section.

At D17, Multiband-retrieved series are also continuous, with few interruptions though. These records

show similar SSA values and dynamics across the three Cap Prud'homme stations (Appendix REF), reflecting consistent surface environmental conditions. The median summer SSA for the three stations is $15.38 \text{ m}^2 \text{ kg}^{-1}$, *i.e.*, grain size is typically ~ 1.5 times larger than in the megadunes. SSA values are typically below $20 \text{ m}^2 \text{ kg}^{-1}$ over the mid-austral summer (December 1 to January 31), with the three stations' outlier-free median SSA equal to $11.80 \text{ m}^2 \text{ kg}^{-1}$. In early and late summer, SSA is often above $30.18 \text{ m}^2 \text{ kg}^{-1}$ (75% percentile), with an October, November and February median of $17.87 \text{ m}^2 \text{ kg}^{-1}$. At this location, SSA does not exhibit any particular increasing or decreasing trend at the seasonal time scale. Abrupt peaks are often registered, with SSA reaching $>40 \text{ m}^2 \text{ kg}^{-1}$, values typical of fresh fallen snow from one day to the next—this is the typical signature of snow precipitation.

SICE 1.6-retrieved SSA for this location are sparser, with missing values typically co-occurring when Multiband signal peaks abruptly, as precipitation is often accompanied by overcast conditions that prevent surface visibility. For D5, D10, and D17, SICE 1.6 yields NaNs for 69.37%, 74.26%, and 74.37% of Multiband data, respectively. The satellite time series agree fairly well with Multiband data on average (biases below $5 \text{ m}^2 \text{ kg}^{-1}$). SICE 1.6 yields a slightly lower mid-summer median of $8.11 \text{ m}^2 \text{ kg}^{-1}$. At the beginning of each summer season, however, satellite SSAs are systematically lower than Multiband measurements, particularly in October, with an average bias of $13.42 \text{ m}^2 \text{ kg}^{-1}$ and maximum differences reaching $25.1 \text{ m}^2 \text{ kg}^{-1}$. Overall, *in situ* and satellite observations are moderately consistent across all years and Cap Prud'homme stations, with a correlation coefficient of $r = 0.71$ at D17.

6 Diagnostic of the results for EAIIST stations

6.1 Multiband issues

The large offset between *in situ* and satellite time series, at EAIIST02 particularly, initially led us to consider a potential instrumental issue in Multiband. We first examined the cross-calibration curves used for the correction at both stations, for each specific wavelength. For EAIIST02, the calibration experiment returned an average $R_{CC} = 1.055 \pm 0.004$, confirming consistency throughout the experiment and across all wavelengths. However, the same analysis for EAIIST01 revealed a much lower cross-calibration ratio, particularly at shorter wavelengths. For example, at 500 nm (Figure 9a), the computed R_{CC} is 0.660 ± 0.003 across the calibration phase. Such a value indicates a large difference in transmission between both channels, which is unexpected and is likely a consequence of a poor locking connection between the optical fibers and the other components, or potential wear of one of the two cosine collectors. While the calibration is designed to compensate for such issue, this is not satisfactory. Concerning the inclinometers, for both EAIIST01 and EAIIST02, exception made for some electrical noise at the beginning of each season, the signal yields stable angles fluctuating within a range of $\pm 2.5^\circ$. However, the inclinometers failed from 2025 onward, which is a known problem at low temperatures (Fig. 9b). This measurement is therefore not exploitable after that date, and no conclusion can be drawn about the potential tilt of the albedometers'

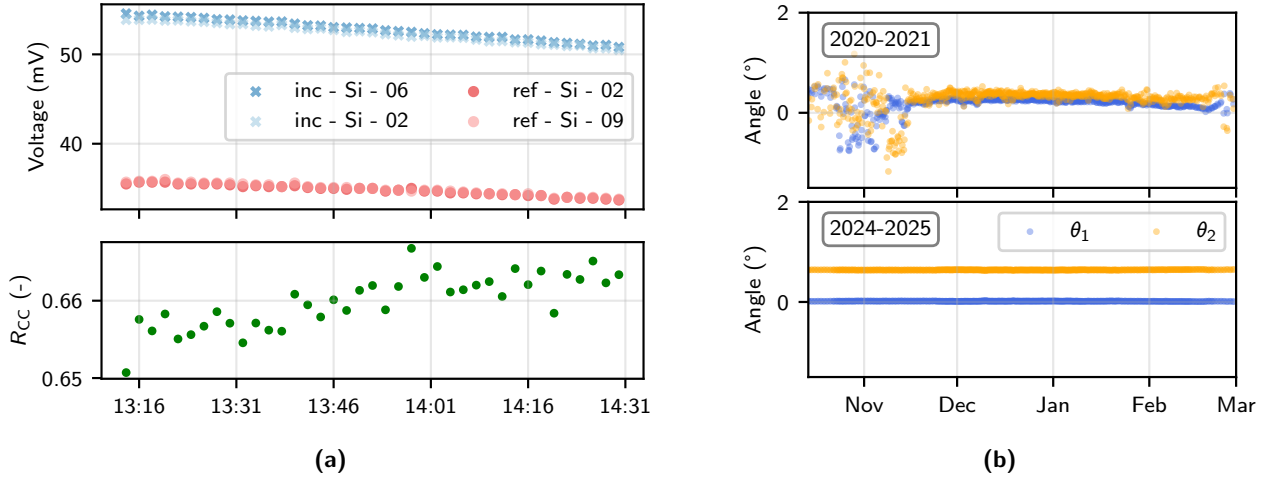


Figure 9: Calibrations and inclinometers | (a) Cross-calibration experiment performed for EAIIST01, carried on on December 29, 2019. In the upper plot, evolution of the raw signals at 500 nm: incident ("inc") and reflected ("ref") channel for the Silicon photodiode ("Si"), and at different steps of the rotating wheel (02, 06, 09). In the lower plot, the ratio computed between the reflected and incident signals acquired at the same step (02). (b) Time series of the tilt angles measured by the inclinometer at EAIIST01 for two representative years.

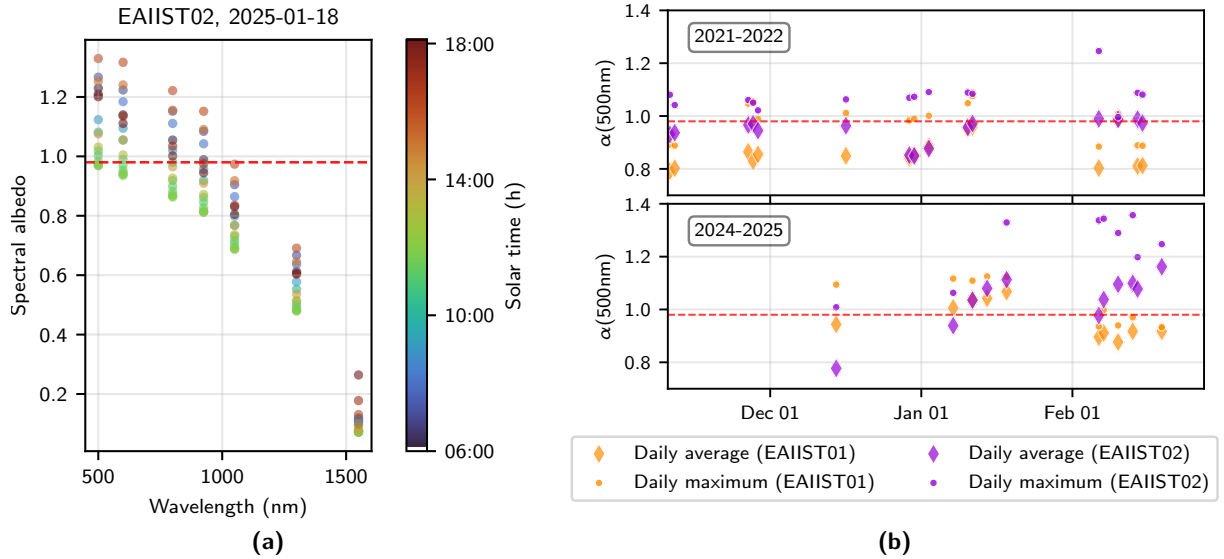


Figure 10: Multiband's albedo non-convergence in the visible | (a) Albedo spectra acquired during a mid-summer day with EAIIST02 albedometer. The dashed red line indicates the expected convergence value of the spectrum at 500 nm (0.98). (b) Interannual evolution of daily average and maximum spectral albedo at 500 nm at both EAIIST stations, during summer days with constant and diffuse light conditions only.

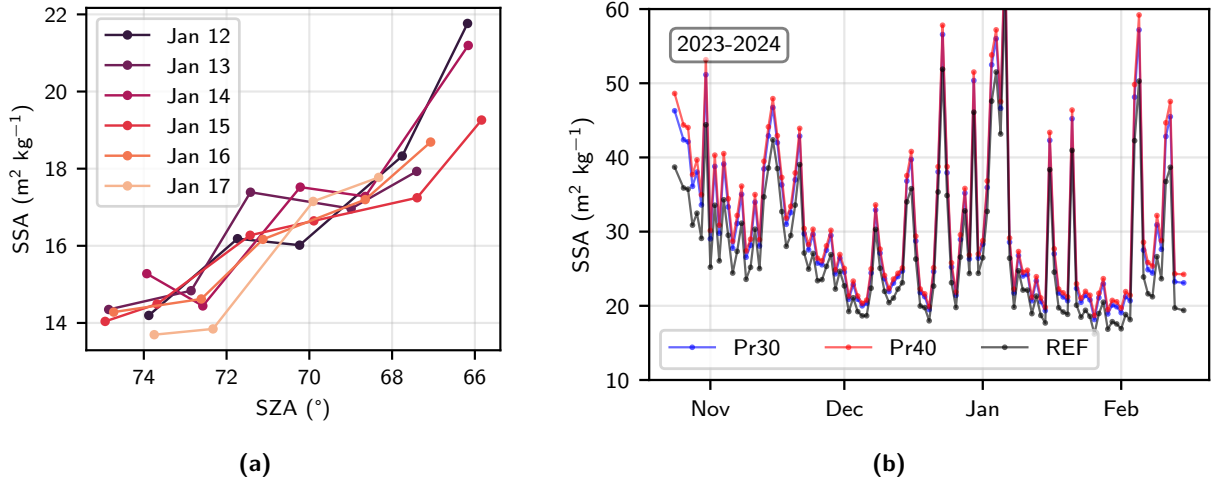


Figure 11: Diagnostic of SICE 1.6 | (a) SSA sub-daily variability induced by SZA in the SICE 1.6 algorithm at EAI-IST01; (b) SICE 1.6 processing with different SZA flattening parameters (REF = 0, Pr30 = 0.30, Pr40 = 0.40). The time series in the figure are from EAIIST01 location (2022–2023).

heads.

When examining the sub-daily variability in albedo spectra, we noticed that in many cases, the values do not converge to 0.98 in the visible range as expected for fresh snow, instead yielding unrealistically high values around 1.2. An example for a recent winter day (with constant and diffuse ambient light) is shown in Figure 10a, showing albedo acquired at any solar time of the day always far above 1 in the visible. We then investigated how daily average and maximum values of spectral albedo at 500 nm evolved over the years at both EAIIST stations (Fig. 10). From the installation in 2020 to 2025, this value has not been constant neither at EAIIST01 nor EAIIST02, despite ideally very similar diffuse light conditions, but it is generally too low and too high respectively. Particularly, in 2025, at EAIIST02 daily average albedo at 500 nm is *always* above 1 by 5% to 15%.

6.2 SICE 1.6 issues

For some seasons, particularly at EAIIST02 (e.g., 2022–2023, Fig. 7 on the right), SICE and Multiband yield completely different grain size dynamics. To investigate, we inspected S-3/OLCI data and SICE 1.6 processing. Following the same approach as with Multiband, we analyzed sub-daily albedo variations from both EAIIST stations, focusing on clear-sky days and excluding hours with $CSI \geq 1.0$ to explore the effect of SZA on the SICE 1.6 algorithm. The analysis, performed on random clusters of consecutive days, revealed strong and non-realistic sub-daily variability, with average deviations of $4.18 \text{ m}^2 \text{ kg}^{-1}$ for EAIIST01 and $3.57 \text{ m}^2 \text{ kg}^{-1}$ for EAIIST02. This variability is day-dependent and can manifest as either a gradual increase in SSA throughout the day or non-directional random fluctuations (Figure 11a), making it difficult to draw precise conclusions.

Since a monotonic increase in SSA is often observed but not physically expected—especially on cloud- and precipitation-free days (Picard et al., 2020)—we applied the SZA flattening factor to reduce its

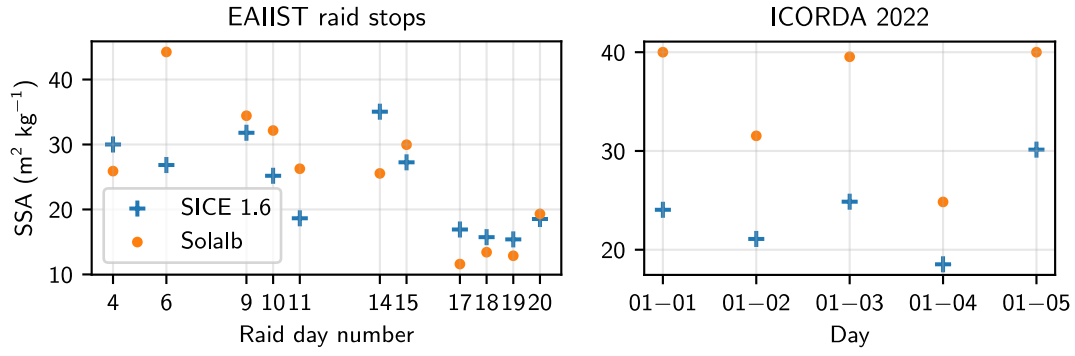


Figure 12: Comparison between SICE 1.6 and Solalb | On the left, Solalb measurements acquired during 2019 EAIIST raid at different locations between Concordia station and the megadune field, against SICE 1.6 retrieved values. On the right, Solalb measurement from the ICORDA campaign, in a fixed location.

influence, as described in Section 4.3.1. This produced two new SSA series obtained with factors $r = 0.3$ (Pr30) and $r = 0.4$ (Pr40). A comparison with the reference processing is shown in Figure 11b. While this adjustment increased SSA values by $\sim 5\text{--}10 \text{ m}^2 \text{ kg}^{-1}$, it was insufficient to fully account for the discrepancy between *in situ* and satellite time series.

6.3 Comparison between SICE 1.6 and Solalb

In order to introduce a third element of comparison, we assessed SICE 1.6's SSA with SSA estimated with Solalb during the EAIIST and ICORDA campaigns. The results are shown in Figure 12.

On the EAIIST traverse, Solalb measurements show a medium-to-strong correlation with SICE 1.6, with $r = 0.68$ and a small bias of $1.31 \text{ m}^2 \text{ kg}^{-1}$. This suggests no obvious bug in the SICE 1.6 retrieval algorithm. For ICORDA, the correlation is very strong ($r = 0.85$), but SICE 1.6's SSA values exhibit a strong negative bias (Bias = $-11.45 \text{ m}^2 \text{ kg}^{-1}$) with respect to Solalb, similar to the behavior observed with Multiband, where SICE 1.6 underestimates SSA compared to *in situ* instruments. However, this last set of measurements is less reliable due to its limited size, only 5 valid points with clear sky conditions.

IV Discussion

7 Considerations on the performance of the instruments

Positive considerations can be drawn about Multiband regarding its continuous functioning without interruption, even in harsh conditions — it ultimately represents a reliable option for exploring snow optical properties in remote environments such as the Antarctic Ice Sheet. In particular, the time series of SSA at the megadunes represents an unprecedented *in-situ* record of grain size evolution over 6 years at such a remote location.

The instrumental issues encountered, particularly at the EAIIST02 station, highlight two critical needs: (i) more accurate calibration procedures and (ii) regular maintenance to address component wear or albedometer displacement. For example, the absence of inclinometer data prevents us from determining

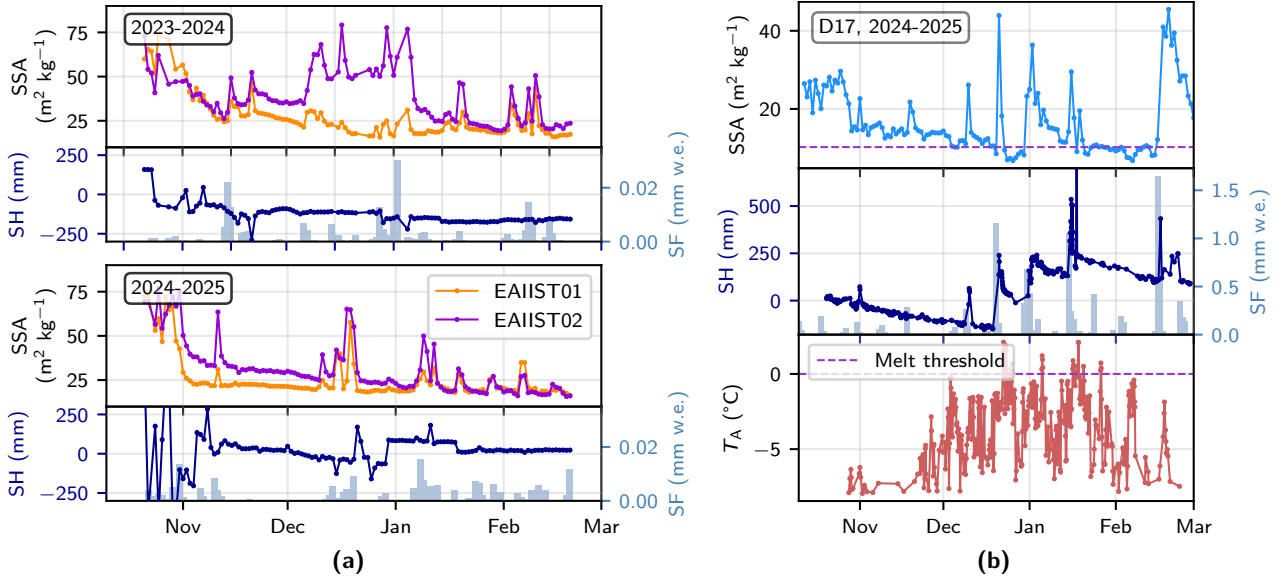


Figure 13: Multiband's SSA and meteorological records | (a) Times series of two representative seasons in the megadunes: Multiband SSA (EAIIST01-orange and EAIIST02-purple, upper plot), CNR4's snow height (SH, dark blue, lower plot) and ERA5 snow fall (SF, light blue, lower plot); (b) representative season at D17: Multiband's SSA (blue, upper plot), snow height and snow fall (central plot) and CNR4's 2 m air temperature (T_A , red, lower plot).

whether a correction factor for albedometer tilting should be applied.

Furthermore, analyzing the signal recorded during the cross-calibration experiment—as we did for both EAIIST stations—is essential. However, further diagnostics are required. While the cross-calibration reflected-to-incident ratio R_{CC} for EAIIST02 was initially very close to 1, suggesting no instrumental issues, the subsequent analysis of albedo spectra (prior to slope correction) revealed significant anomalies. Over the years, the variability of spectral albedo in the visible range indicates that the effectiveness of the cosine collectors—and the system as a whole—may have degraded since installation, rendering the initial calibration invalid for recent years.

For instance, at EAIIST02, the unrealistically high spectral albedo at 500 nm (~ 1.2) suggests a relative decrease in the response intensity of the upward-oriented cosine collector. This likely caused a systematic increase in the reflected-to-incident ratio (Eq. (9)). Supporting this hypothesis, previous studies (e.g., , Liu et al., 2022) have shown that Teflon, as an engineering plastic, undergoes significant molecular changes when exposed to prolonged UV radiation, altering its optical properties. The continuous exposure to solar radiation of the upward cosine collector can then be considered a cause of its degradation. Additionally, we cannot exclude the possibility that other components of the system contributed to the miscalibration. For instance, optical fibers can experience signal losses due to aging, stress, or bending—the latter likely occurring during field deployment (Bunge et al., 2017).

8 Geophysical interpretation of the time series

Despite the imperfection of the estimates and the technical issues, some interesting interpretations about the signal recorded from both the *in situ* equipment and the satellite can be drawn.

In the megadunes field, Multiband was able to capture different grain size dynamics on the accumulation (EAIIST02) and erosion (EAIIST01) zones of a dune. Fahnestock et al., 2000 already found significant differences between the deposition side—where finer grains of fresh or wind-fractured snow are accumulated—and the ablation side—where deeper, coarser layers are exposed to surface, such as depth hoar. We compared the two different types of evolution concerning the accumulation zone (EAIIST02) with snow falls (obtained from ERA5 reanalysis) and snow heights (SR50 sensor) patterns. In Figure 13a, the uppermost plot shows a representative season where EAIIST02's Multiband registers much higher SSAs than EAIIST01 (erosion) in mid-summer, of $\sim 25 \text{ m}^2 \text{ kg}^{-1}$. This is well explained by the large input of fresh snow by the several precipitations occurring in November and December. The lower panel shows a drier season, where reduced early-summer precipitation prevents the accumulation zone SSA from exceeding the erosion zone by more than $\sim 10 \text{ m}^2 \text{ kg}^{-1}$. In both cases, precipitation events produce an immediate SSA increase at both sites. In the erosion zone, SSA rapidly returns to pre-event values due to wind redistribution and re-exposure of older glazed layers, while in the accumulation zone the decrease is more gradual and variable, reflecting a mix of wind deposition, grain fracturing, and sintering processes.

Regarding Multiband records from Cap Prud'homme and the coastal area, we observe that grain size dynamics are well captured both at the daily and seasonal time scale. We first observe that SSA has the tendency to be lowest in early December to end of January, when summer temperatures are highest (Figure 13b). This reflects well the effect of wet metamorphism, as also previously stated by Arioli et al., 2023 based on Vandecrux et al., 2022's finding that $\text{SSA} = 10.22 \text{ m}^2 \text{ kg}^{-1}$ represents a possible threshold for discriminating days of unlikely melt and days of intense snow melt. In fact, several days of grain size below this critical value are observed at the three stations, particularly around end of December and mid-February. The snowfall dynamics are also well visible in the time series: precipitations yield an abrupt increase in the SSA up to values typical of fresh fallen snow ($\text{SSA} > 60 \text{ m}^2 \text{ kg}^{-1}$, Domine et al., 2009). These events are usually followed by a more gradual increase in grain size—SSA decrease rate of $\sim 1.5 \text{ m}^2 \text{ kg}^{-1} \text{ d}^{-1}$ —given by the coupled effects of wind and metamorphism, with values between 10 and $40 \text{ m}^2 \text{ kg}^{-1}$. Namely, snowfalls are typically related to a strong surface temperature gradient, one of the most important drivers of dry metamorphism (Colbeck, 1982). We can clearly see how SSA peaks directly correlate with snowfalls recorded by both the SR50 sensor (abrupt peaks in snow height curve) and ERA'5 snow falls in Figure 13b.

V Conclusion

Through this work, we studied the dynamics of snow grain size retrieved from surface spectral albedo records. We demonstrated that both *in situ* and satellite-borne instruments are valuable tools for exploring

their spatio-temporal nature. In particular, our custom Multiband albedometer provided consistent and continuous SSA records, enabling detailed insights into snow grain size evolution in response to local meteorological and environmental conditions. This is especially relevant for the megadunes area, where data are extremely scarce and surface processes remain poorly understood. Sentinel-3/OLCI data processed with SICE 1.6 showed moderate agreement with Multiband, a promising result that opens the door to broader space-borne geophysical exploration of Antarctica with unprecedented spatial resolution. However, validating satellite-retrieved SSA is not yet possible for all considered situations, particularly in the megadunes' accumulation zone, where Multiband and SICE 1.6 systematically yield different SSAs.

For these reasons, future studies should address the technical issues identified in this work. Our diagnostic pipeline for Multiband data processing should be systematically implemented for each station before applying the SSA retrieval algorithm of Arioli et al., 2023. This would ensure that instrumental issues—such as poor cross-calibration, non-converging albedo spectra in the visible range, and potential instrument tilting—are identified and corrected through post-processing. A similar approach could be applied to SICE 1.6, potentially revising the algorithm, as we showed it is highly sensitive to solar zenith angles, which may compromise the reliability of its SSA estimates. Additionally, future studies could account for differences in grain type across locations. While we assumed constant absorption enhancement parameter and asymmetry factor to apply ART theory, more site-specific snow grain parametrizations may improve SSA retrieval.

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